Product Charter & PRD

An AI-native travel platform: build, book, and trade trips — for agents and travelers

Working codename: Trellis · Owner: Syed Hassaan Saleem · Version 0.3 (Charter+PRD) · Status: Draft · July 2026

Name note: “Trellis” is a placeholder. “TripForge” is unavailable (active US LLC plus live sites) and most obvious travel names are taken — a trademark and domain search is required before naming.

1. Vision & mission

Vision. Become the category leader for how trips are built, priced, booked, and traded — the default operating system for travel professionals and the AI planning layer travelers reach for when they want a real, bookable, budget-fit trip.

Mission. Collapse itinerary building, live-priced booking, and a two-sided trip marketplace into one AI-native platform, so a great trip can be created once and sold many times — by an agent to a client, by an agent to another agent, or self-served by a traveler.

North Star metric: booked trip value flowing through the platform (GBV). Every pillar — AI planner, bookings, and marketplace resale — is judged by whether it increases trips created that convert into paid, booked travel.

2. Strategy — how we win

Leadership is won by owning a position no incumbent holds: a **neutral, AI-native platform that is simultaneously a professional tool, a bookable inventory layer, and a marketplace** — across both the agent (B2B) and traveler (B2C) sides. The sequencing is deliberate:

- **Land with the tool.** Win agents with a best-in-class, budget-aware AI itinerary builder tied to live inventory — a known, monetizable need.
- **Convert to a network.** Turn that installed base into marketplace liquidity: agents resell and white-label each other's trips (the SaaS-enabled-marketplace playbook — come for the tool, stay for the network).
- **Open the demand side.** Add a consumer AI planner powered by marketplace itineraries, with a “book with an agent or self-drive it” fork — the consumer surface feeds the marketplace instead of competing as a generic planner.

3. Problem

For agents: itinerary tools make one agent faster but every agent rebuilds the same trips and is capped by the destinations they know; there is no liquid, self-serve market to buy or resell finished trips. Inventory (bedbanks) is disconnected from the build and client experience.

For travelers: consumer AI planners produce pretty itineraries that are not priced against real, bookable inventory and cannot be executed end-to-end. Travelers still juggle separate tabs for flights, stays, cars, transfers, and activities — and have no clean path to hand a plan to a professional when it gets complex.

4. Product overview

Trellis is one platform with two surfaces on a shared engine.

Professional surface (agents): build client-ready, budget-aware itineraries with AI; book net-rate inventory inline with markup control; and list, discover, resell, and white-label finished itineraries on a two-sided marketplace. Sale modes: agent→client (B2B2C) and agent→agent (B2B2B).

Consumer surface (travelers): describe a trip and a budget; AI assembles a live-priced, bookable itinerary; the traveler either self-drives the bookings or requests a marketplace agent to refine and execute it. The consumer surface is powered by the same inventory and by agent-built marketplace itineraries.

Shared engine: AI itinerary generation, a budget allocator, a unified inventory/booking layer, identity and payments, and the marketplace catalogue — all reused across both surfaces.

5. Goals & non-goals

Goals

- A budget-aware AI planner whose output is real, live-priced, and bookable end-to-end.
- A liquid agent→agent marketplace for finished, vetted itineraries with resale, white-label, ratings, and revenue-share.
- A consumer surface that converts self-serve planning into booked trips and qualified agent handoffs.
- Category leadership on GBV and marketplace liquidity within the beachhead niche, then adjacent niches.

Non-goals (explicitly out of scope)

- **Do not build a ride-hailing / driver fleet.** Ground transport and private drivers are integrated via third-party transfer APIs, never owned. A real-time mobility marketplace is a separate, heavily-regulated company.
- **Do not be merchant-of-record for flights early.** Flights carry near-zero margin and high support load; deep-link or defer owning the booking until ops maturity justifies it.
- **Do not depend on Airbnb inventory.** Airbnb has no open booking API and its terms forbid reselling API content; short-term rentals come via property-manager channels later, not the Airbnb brand.
- **Do not chase generic consumer trip-planning** on its own axis; the consumer surface exists to feed the marketplace, not to win a standalone affiliate race.

6. Users & personas

Persona	Type	Core need	What Trellis gives them
Solo / small agency	Agent (B2B)	Build & sell trips fast; thin destination coverage	Buy ready-made vetted itineraries; book inline; sell faster
Specialist / DMC agent	Agent (B2B)	Monetize destination expertise beyond own clients	Wholesale itineraries to other agents — a new revenue line
Host agency / consortium	Agent (B2B)	Equip many sub-agents with consistent product	Distribute curated, on-brand trips & inventory from one place
Self-serve traveler	Consumer (B2C)	A real, budget-fit, bookable trip without 20 tabs	AI plan priced to budget; self-drive or hand to an agent

7. Competitive landscape

The market has **four competitor groups**, and no player spans them all: (1) **build/book tools** for agents (Lato, Travefy, TravelJoy, WeTravel); (2) **marketplace-adjacent players** (Thatch/Mindtrip, Fora, Community.Travel); (3) **consumer AI planners** (Mindtrip, Layla, Wanderlog, Wonderplan…); and (4) **OTA / meta giants** adding AI (Expedia Romie, Booking, Kayak, Google). Trellis is the only

position that unifies professional tooling, a neutral resale marketplace, and a consumer surface — with a real agent behind the booking.

7a. Build-and-book tools (agent side).

Feature	Trellis	Lato	Travefy	TravelJoy	WeTravel	Bedbanks*
AI itinerary builder	✓	✓	–	–	✗	✗
Budget-aware, live-priced planning	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Content / media library	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗	–
Client-facing trip app	✓	✓	✓	–	–	✗
In-platform net-rate booking	✓	✓	✗	–	✗	✓
Activities / transfers / car in one flow	✓	✗	✗	✗	–	✗
Sell trips to clients (B2B2C)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗
Resell trips agent→agent (B2B2B)	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Consumer self-serve + agent handoff	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Discover / “What's Hot” inspiration feed	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Ratings / verified sellers	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Agents earn from selling product	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗

Legend: ✓ full – partial ✗ absent. *Bedbanks = RateHawk / Hotelbeds / WebBeds / TBO.

7b. Consumer AI planners & OTA giants (the group the expanded consumer surface competes with). This is a crowded, fast-moving, well-funded field — Mindtrip launched in-chat agentic flight booking (Sabre + PayPal); Layla is backed by Booking.com and Skyscanner founders and acquired Roam Around; Expedia's Romie plans, books, and troubleshoots across app, iMessage, and WhatsApp.

Player / group	Live-priced	Budget-fit	Books in-app	Human-accountable	Marketplace-fed trips	Pro / agent side
Trellis	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Mindtrip (Sabre/PayPal)	✓	–	✓	✗	✗	✗
Layla (Skyscanner/Booking)	✓	–	–	✓	–	✗
Wanderlog	–	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
ChatGPT / Wonderplan (plan-only)	✗	–	✗	✗	✗	✗
Expedia Romie	✓	–	✓	–	✗	–
Booking / Kayak / Google	✓	–	–	✗	✗	✗

Columns: Live-priced (real, current prices) · **Budget-fit** (reliably plans to a budget) · **Human-accountable** (a real person completes/owns the booking) · **Marketplace-fed** (itineraries sourced from a resale network).

7c. Marketplace-adjacent players (each already trades packaged travel, but not on our axis):

Player	Model	Who trades with whom	Gap Trellis owns
Thatch (Mindtrip)	Marketplace for curated guides & planning services; sellers keep ~90%	Creators / local experts → consumers	Professional agent→agent resale with net-rate markup
Fora Travel	Host agency: AI portal, 175k+ suppliers, commission tracking (15k+ advisors, $2.5B booked)	Advisors book under Fora's umbrella	Neutral peer marketplace vs a single host-agency roof
Community.Travel	Invitation-only B2B marketplace + API for multi-day tours	DMCs / tour organizers → tour operators	Self-serve resale for the long tail of retail agents

7d. What the analysis says — where we win

Reviewers consistently sort consumer tools into **three tiers**: plan-only (ChatGPT, Wonderplan — the itinerary is homework you finish elsewhere); partial-booking (Mindtrip, Wanderlog — some in-app booking or deep links); and **booked-with-a-human-accountable** — an "AI travel agent," where the plan runs on live prices and a real person reviews and completes it. That third tier wins exactly when trips are expensive or fragile (non-refundable fares, visa timing, groups that can't reschedule).

> **The decisive signal:** only ~8% of travelers say they're comfortable letting AI book on their behalf (Expedia/YouGov, 2026). Pure AI-books-it planners hit a trust ceiling; the human-accountable tier is where high-value trips convert. Trellis's "request an agent" fork puts a real marketplace agent in that tier by design — and unlike Layla's bolted-on "expert consultations," the agent is sourced from a two-sided network that also supplies the itineraries.

- **vs consumer planners (Mindtrip/Layla/Wanderlog):** they optimize a solo self-serve plan; several claim budget-awareness but execute it poorly (documented out-of-budget hotel results). Trellis differentiates on reliable budget-fit against live inventory, a real agent-accountable option, and marketplace-sourced trips — not another pretty planner.
- **vs OTA / meta giants (Expedia/Booking/Kayak/Google):** they own inventory and price but compete on the booking/search axis; their AI is a concierge over their own supply, not a neutral professional tool or an agent-to-agent marketplace. We are complementary to inventory, not trying to out-inventory them.
- **vs discovery incumbents:** inspiration-to-plan (Layla's video feed, Mindtrip's "Start Anywhere" + community guides) already exists — so our "What's Hot" feed must win on being bookable, agent-connected, and marketplace-fed, not on the format itself.

> **Honest risk:** this places Trellis against far better-funded consumer players. The defensible move is not to win the consumer planner race head-on — it is to make the consumer surface a demand funnel into the agent marketplace, where the moat (liquidity + human-accountable agents) lives.

8. Product pillars

- **Pillar 1 — Build (AI planning).** Budget-aware AI itinerary generation, content/media library, branded proposals, client app.
- **Pillar 2 — Book (inventory).** Net-rate hotels + activities + car + transfers booked inline with markup control, via aggregator APIs.
- **Pillar 3 — Trade (marketplace).** List, discover, resell, and white-label finished itineraries; ratings, verified sellers, revenue-share.
- **Pillar 4 — Consumer surface.** Self-serve AI planner with "book with an agent or self-drive it" fork and a "What's Hot" discovery feed, powered by marketplace supply.

9. Core requirements (PRD)

9.1 AI itinerary generation (budget-aware)

- Inputs: destination(s), dates, party size, trip style/pace, and a total budget (hard cap or target).
- The planner must assemble against **live-priced, bookable inventory** — not static suggestions — and keep the assembled plan within budget with a visible breakdown per category and per day.
- AI assists: draft itineraries, per-category markup/pricing suggestions, listing quality scoring, and resale-match recommendations.
- Output is a structured, standardized itinerary schema so the same trip can be booked, listed, resold, and white-labeled.

9.2 Budget allocation architecture

The allocator splits the budget across categories, pulls live options per category, and assembles to fit, re-balancing when a category runs over. Indicative default weights (tunable by trip type):

Budget category	Typical share	Notes
Flights / long-haul transport	35–45%	Dominant line; budget anchor. Deep-link or defer owning the booking early.
Accommodation	30–40%	Primary margin driver (net-rate markup).
Activities / tickets	10–15%	High-intent, good commission; fills the daily plan.
Local transport / transfers / car	5–10%	Integrated via aggregators; includes private driver.
Buffer / ancillaries	5–10%	Insurance, eSIM, contingency; high-margin add-ons.

Engineering realities (must-design-for): prices are volatile and quotes expire — the system needs a quote-then-book flow with hold/expiry and multi-currency handling; and each aggregator has its own merchant model, refund path, and failed-booking edge cases. The booking/ops layer is a larger build than the AI itself.

9.3 Bookable component map

What the AI can actually price and book — and where the margin is. This defines the ceiling of the product.

Component	Supply / API path	Bookable via API?	Est. margin	MVP
Hotels	Bedbanks (RateHawk, Hotelbeds, TBO, WebBeds)	Yes (net rates)	~10–25%	Yes
Activities / tickets	Viator, GetYourGuide, Tiqets, Klook	Yes	~10–30%	Yes
Car rental	CarTrawler-type / GDS car	Yes	~5–15%	Yes
Transfers / private driver	Mozio, Jayride, HolidayTaxis, GetTransfer	Yes	~5–15%	Yes
Flights	Duffel, Amadeus, Kiwi, Travelport	Yes (heavy ops)	~flat fee	Deep-link
Short-term rentals	PM channels (Hostaway, Guesty) — not Airbnb	Partial	varies	Defer
Insurance / eSIM	Affiliate partners	Yes	high	Yes (add-on)
Restaurants	OpenTable / TheFork	Content only	~0	Content

9.4 Booking, quotes & payments

- Quote-then-book with price hold/expiry; re-quote on expiry; transparent currency conversion.
- Cart assembles multi-supplier components; partial-failure handling (one component fails, others hold).
- Markup engine (agent-controlled) on net rates; take-rate on marketplace transactions; commission capture on activities/transfers/car.
- Clarify merchant-of-record per component early — it drives payments, refunds, and liability design.

9.5 Agent vs. self-drive fork

- **Self-drive:** traveler books the assembled cart themselves; platform earns markup/commission on routed supply.
- **Request agent:** itinerary is handed to a marketplace agent who refines, executes complex/high-touch bookings, and upsells; platform earns take-rate. This is what keeps the consumer surface feeding the B2B marketplace.

9.6 Marketplace

- List / discover / license / resell / white-label finished itineraries; per-seller control over who may resell and at what terms.

- Ratings, verified sellers, standardized schema, revenue-share enforcement; provenance and client-ownership controls to manage channel conflict.

9.7 Discover / “What's Hot” feed

A top-of-funnel inspiration surface — a scrollable feed of trending places, reels, and “what's happening now” for a city or destination — that pulls travelers in before they know where they're going and re-engages them between trips. It sits on the consumer surface (Pillar 4).

> **Hard rule:** every feed item must be actionable — tapping a reel or place opens a plannable, budget-priced itinerary (add to trip / book / hand to an agent). A feed that only shows pretty pictures is engagement with no conversion; tied to planning, it becomes the acquisition top of the funnel.

Content sourcing (licensed and real only — no scraped image-search results, no fabricated place photos):

Layer	Source	Role
Place & destination imagery	Google Places Photos, Unsplash, Pexels	Licensed, mostly-free base imagery for venues & destinations
“What's happening now”	Events APIs (PredictHQ, Ticketmaster, Eventbrite)	Real, current, date-matched events — the dynamic, differentiated signal
Social reels	YouTube / Instagram / TikTok official embeds	Reel format without re-hosting; rights stay with the platform
Authentic UGC (moat)	Agent- & traveler-submitted trip photos/reels	Real content tied to bookable marketplace itineraries
AI (curation, not fabrication)	In-house models	Rank, personalize, tag, caption; build clearly-labeled motion graphics (maps, collages) from licensed inputs — never passed off as real place footage

> **Do-not:** do not scrape Google image search or re-host third-party photos, and do not present AI-generated imagery as a real photo of a place — both are legal/trust risks that are disqualifying in a product people pay against. “Augmenting” scraped images with a few licensed ones does not cure the underlying infringement.

10. Monetization

Stream	Source	Notes
SaaS subscription	Agents / agencies	Predictable base; the acquisition hook (Pillar 1).
Marketplace take-rate	Agent→agent & agent→client resale	Core defensible revenue; scales with liquidity.
Booking margin / commission	Hotels, activities, car, transfers	Markup on net rates + partner commissions.
Ancillaries	Insurance, eSIM, add-ons	High-margin attach on booked trips.
Consumer handoff fee	Traveler → agent conversions	Take-rate when self-serve routes to a marketplace agent.

11. Go-to-market & roadmap to leadership

Phase	Focus	Key deliverables	Leadership milestone
P0 — MVP	Agent build+book+seed marketplace	AI planner (budget-aware); 1 bedbank + activities + transfers + car; basic resale/white-label; ratings	Live liquidity in 1–2 destination niches
P1 — Marketplace scale	Deepen supply & liquidity	More sellers, more niches; markup/pricing AI; provenance & revenue-share hardening	Default resale network in the beachhead
P2 — Consumer surface	Open demand side	Consumer AI planner; self-drive vs agent fork; “What's Hot” discovery feed; ancillaries; deep-link flights	Consumer demand feeding agent supply

Phase	Focus	Key deliverables	Leadership milestone
P3 — Category leadership	Own build+book+trade	Direct supplier contracting where volume justifies; multi-region; consortium tooling; flights-as-merchant if ops ready	Recognized leader on GBV & liquidity

12. Success metrics

Metric	Definition	Why it matters
GBV (North Star)	Booked trip value through the platform	Single measure of real traction across pillars
Marketplace take-rate revenue / active agent	Resale revenue per agent	Proves the network, not just the tool
Resold : self-built ratio	Trips sourced from network vs built from scratch	Direct signal the marketplace wedge works
Plan→book conversion	Itineraries that become paid bookings	Measures the budget-aware planner's real value
Agent-handoff rate (consumer)	Self-serve plans routed to an agent	Shows the consumer surface feeds the marketplace

13. Risks & mitigations

Risk	Impact	Mitigation
Cold-start / empty marketplace	High	SaaS-first adoption; seed with power-seller agencies; launch niche-by-niche
Channel conflict (resell to rivals)	Med–High	White-label resale; client-ownership controls; clear revenue-share terms
Funded incumbents extend in	Med	Move first on peer-resale liquidity; lock supply via seller economics
Inventory / API dependence	Med	Aggregators first; direct contracting only when volume justifies
Flights ops & thin margin	Med	Deep-link/defer merchant-of-record; treat as budget anchor, not profit
Booking price volatility	Med	Quote-then-book with hold/expiry; robust re-quote & partial-failure handling

14. Compliance & regulatory

- **Package-travel rules.** Bundling accommodation + transport into one sale can trigger package-travel / dynamic-packaging regulation (e.g., the EU Package Travel Directive) with liability and insolvency-protection obligations. Design the bundling flow with this in mind.
- **Ground-transport licensing.** Avoided by integrating licensed transfer providers rather than dispatching drivers ourselves.
- **Supplier API terms.** Respect each aggregator's resale, rebranding, and merchant-of-record terms (notably Airbnb's prohibition on reselling API content).
- **Payments & data.** Merchant-of-record, PCI scope, and cross-border data handling depend on per-component payment design — resolve early.

15. Open questions (to validate before build)

- Which beachhead niche/destination gives the fastest first pocket of marketplace liquidity?
- Will specialist agents actually resell to potential competitors under white-label + client-ownership controls? (Test with real agents.)

- Merchant-of-record model per component — platform-as-MoR vs supplier-as-MoR, and its refund/liability implications.
- Unit economics: blended take-rate + booking margin per trip vs CAC on each side of the marketplace.

Market and margin figures are directional ranges synthesized from 2025–2026 industry sources and vary by scope, market, and negotiated terms. Competitor scoring reflects public positioning and should be spot-checked before external use. “Trellis” is a placeholder pending trademark/domain clearance.